



**MESSAGE OF SUPPORT BY THE FEDUSA PRESIDENT:
GODFREY SELEMATSELA
PSCBC STRATEGIC SESSION**

**“Collective Bargaining in the Digital Era: Building Trust,
Managing Disputes, and Ensuring Good Governance”**

Programme Director,
Leadership of the PSCBC,
Representatives of Organised Labour and the Employer,
Distinguished delegates, colleagues,

On behalf of the Federation of Unions of South Africa - FEDUSA, I bring you our full support for this important strategic session of the Public Service Coordinating Bargaining Council.

The theme before us is not academic. It is real. It speaks to what public servants are living through every day. We are negotiating wages, resolving disputes and managing institutions at a time when technology is changing the workplace faster than most of our systems can keep up.

Digital systems, artificial intelligence, data platforms and remote working tools are no longer ideas for the future. They are here. They shape how teachers record marks, how nurses capture patient information, how administrators process payroll and how managers measure performance.

The question we must ask is simple. Is this technological shift strengthening collective bargaining or weakening it?

At FEDUSA, we believe collective bargaining must never be left behind. If technology changes the workplace, then it must also shape the way we negotiate, resolve disputes and build trust.

The PSCBC remains one of the most important governance structures in the public service. It is not just a meeting place. It is where power is balanced through negotiation. It is where disagreements are resolved before they become crises. It is where agreements give stability to the public service.

We must protect that role.

Building trust in a digital era is not easy. Information moves quickly. Rumours spread faster than facts. Decisions are increasingly driven by data that many workers do not fully see or understand.

Trust cannot be built on speeches. It is built on transparency, consistency and honesty.

Technology can help us. Digital document systems can improve access to information. Shared data platforms can make negotiations more informed. Real time communication can reduce confusion.

But technology can also create fear. Workers will not trust systems that monitor them without consultation. They will not accept algorithms that affect their performance ratings, deployment or restructuring without clarity. They will not support change if it feels imposed.

This is why collective bargaining must now include digital governance. Data protection must be negotiated. The use of monitoring tools must be transparent. Any system that influences employment conditions must be open to scrutiny.

If technology affects workers, workers must have a voice in how it is used.

On managing disputes, the digital era presents both risks and opportunities.

Disputes can escalate quickly when misinformation spreads online. A single message can inflame tensions across departments within hours.

At the same time, digital tools can help us manage disputes better. Case tracking systems can reduce delays. Virtual hearings can increase access where appropriate. Improved record keeping can strengthen fairness.

But speed must never replace justice. Efficiency must never override due process. The heart of labour relations remains fairness and procedural integrity.

We must also acknowledge that digital transformation itself is becoming a source of disputes. Remote work arrangements. Digital monitoring. Cybersecurity responsibilities. Technology driven restructuring. These issues are already emerging.

The PSCBC must not wait for conflict to explode. We must anticipate these questions and develop clear frameworks before tensions rise.

On governance, the fundamentals remain the same.

Good governance means agreements are honoured. It means financial realities are shared honestly. It means data presented at the bargaining table is credible and tested. It means decisions are explained.

We now have more data than ever before. But data without integrity is dangerous. Selective numbers can mislead. Incomplete information can distort negotiations.

We must strengthen the technical capacity of the PSCBC to interrogate fiscal information, workforce statistics and digital transformation plans. Evidence must support negotiations, not manipulate them.

FEDUSA believes in responsible unionism. We defend workers firmly. But we also understand that institutions must remain sustainable. Strong collective bargaining requires discipline, preparation and integrity from all parties.

Technology must not weaken social dialogue. It must deepen it.

Public servants are not barriers to innovation. They are the backbone of service delivery. They are the people who interact with digital systems daily. They understand what works and what does not.

If digital transformation happens without them, it will create resistance. If it happens with them, it will create ownership.

This strategic session must move us from discussion to action. We must modernise processes where necessary. We must strengthen communication. We must embed digital safeguards into agreements. We must commit to transparency.

The future of collective bargaining will not be decided by software. It will be decided by leadership, trust and partnership.

FEDUSA stands ready to work with all parties to strengthen the PSCBC as a credible, modern and trusted institution.

Together, we can ensure that collective bargaining in this new era remains a pillar of stability, fairness and good governance in the public service.

I thank you.

Amandla!!